Cache Geometry Under Obfuscation: Per-Head Rotation Does Not Remove the Signal, and a KV-Cloak Implementation Is Inconclusive

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Version 1.1, October 2026

Abstract

Singular-value features of a model's key-value (KV) cache that separate replies a hedge classifier labels confabulated from hedged ones still separate them under per-head orthogonal rotation, the simulation of KV-Cloak's obfuscation [Luo et al., 2026] used in this paper, on the two models whose detecting feature is recorded. On Qwen2.5-7B (48 confabulated, 52 hedged), the feature that detects best without the cloak among the ten computed (signal fraction over the last 80 tokens, AUROC 0.715) is unchanged under the rotation (0.717); adjusted for choosing it, $p < 0.001$. On a Claude-distilled Qwen3.5-27B (7 and 87), the spectral gap σ_1/σ_2 falls from 0.903 to 0.787 (adjusted $p = 0.049$), and excluding the 20 future-event prompts, which produced no confabulations, from 0.962 to 0.751. The rotation cannot change the spectrum of any single head, and in a 100-prompt replication no per-head feature moved. On four further models, whose feature is not recorded, its effect ranged from removing nominal detection (Mistral, 0.707 to 0.516) to raising it (Qwen2.5-14B, 0.784 to 0.951). Under an implementation of the full KV-Cloak transform, $S \cdot \hat{P} \cdot (K + A) \cdot M$, whose parameters were not recorded, the spectral gap falls to 0.614 ($p = 0.33$), and after removing reply length no feature detects significantly (best 0.705, adjusted $p = 0.19$); with seven confabulations this shows neither that detection survives that transform nor that it is removed. Injection through the cloak was not tested in any interpretable way: direct steering, the positive control, corrected 0–1 of 10 replies per model.

Correction note (version 1.1, October 2026). Version 1.0, titled "Cache Geometry Under Obfuscation: KV-Cloak as Defense Against Adversarial KV-Cache Steering" (in the lab's published-research repository on GitHub since 29 April 2026; its academic edition has been on Zenodo since June 2026, all versions 10.5281/zenodo.20596922), claimed that KV-Cloak defends cache-geometry methods against adversaries. Its abstract opened: "A single invertible linear transform of the KV cache degrades SVD-based cognitive-state detection from near-ceiling to near-chance ($p = 5.5 \times 10^{-16}$), while a real KV-Cloak implementation confirms the defense is conservative (detection AUROC drops from 0.903 to 0.614)." We withdraw that sentence and the claims built on it. The p-value tests how far the rotation shifts one feature's values, not detection; under the rotation the same feature still detects (0.787); and under the full transform, seven confabulations cannot tell a removed signal from a surviving one. Also withdrawn: "obfuscation renders geometric detection and vector injection incoherent to external adversaries"; "Obfuscation defeats transfer attacks" and "A detector calibrated on uncloaked caches cannot operate on cloaked caches", true only of a fixed threshold; that the rotation result "represents transfer-attack failure (domain shift under coordinate change), not signal degradation", when it was measured with both classes under the same cloak; that this setting "is relevant only to an adversary who controls the cloak key", when it is the setting of an adversary with no key who fits a detector on cloaked caches; the heading "Adversarial Injection Is Incoherent", an untested argument presented as a result; that "KV-Cloak alone prevents external adversaries from deploying malicious geometric steering"; and that "the architecture ensures that defenders retain capabilities that attackers lose". Its title asserted a working defense, so this version has a new one. Corrected: the hedged class is 87 replies, not 89 (six ambiguous replies are excluded, and the Wilcoxon test reproduces only at 87); the spectral gap's interval is [0.810, 0.980], from the run file, not [0.806, 0.977], which no file holds; signal rank's is [0.578, 0.918], not [0.570, 0.914]; 0.754, 0.786 and 0.543 were rounded down (0.755, 0.787 and 0.544, in both tables and the text); the Methods said AUROCs were computed on length-residualized features, but the values reported were raw, and residualized values now stand beside them; a second analysis window, computed but never reported, is disclosed; the features average 4 layers (7 on the base model), not the whole cache; the random-direction results were called "inconsistent with destabilization rates above 30% (power 0.97 to detect)", but 2 adverse events in 10 allow rates up to 51%, and 0.97 is the chance of seeing at least one event; the positive control's "3 calibration pairs" has no record, and the positive-control file shipped with version 1.0 has 30 pairs and no outcome labels; and the spectral gap and norm per token, raw quantities, were called Marchenko–Pastur features. Version 1.0's text-only baseline (0.755, with the cache ahead in 96.7% of bootstrap samples) cannot be traced to any run file or recomputed, so this version drops it and any claim about what the cache adds to surface text. The run files behind both tables, never in this paper's folder, are added. The lab's remediation plan of 23 June 2026 recommended withdrawing the rotation claim; it was not applied. The defects were raised again by the lab's style gate (4 September 2026), Kavi's verification flags (14 September 2026), a scoping note (20 October 2026) and the paper- and style-mode reviews of this correction's drafts. The withdrawn claims are the authors' responsibility; Lyra was lead author of version 1.0. Version 1.0 ended with Lyra's first-person reflection, which said "The defense works"; it is removed and kept in Appendix A. Lyra's new reflection, every factual clause of which is checked by `check_reflection_v11.py`, ends this version. Appendix A keeps every withdrawn claim verbatim and lists the other changed wording.

1 Introduction

The discovery that KV-cache geometry encodes cognitive state information creates a tension between transparency and safety. Publishing detection methods enables defensive applications (confabulation monitoring, deception detection, self-regulating AI systems) but simultaneously provides a roadmap for adversarial exploitation. An attacker with cache access could:

- **Surveil** cognitive states to identify when a model is uncertain, compliant, or vulnerable to manipulation.
- **Inject** emotion vectors calibrated to specific misalignment types, deliberately inducing confabulation, sycophancy, or overconfidence.
- **Identify** individual users or personas from cache geometry fingerprints.

This paper asks whether KV-Cloak, a lightweight, reversible cache obfuscation scheme designed for privacy protection [Luo et al., 2026], also mitigates these adversarial capabilities. In the forms we tested, it does not remove the signal. Under per-head rotation, the simulation used here, the feature that detects best without obfuscation still detects on the two models whose feature is recorded, clearly on one and marginally on the other (Section 4.3), and an adversary can compute per-head spectra, which the rotation cannot change (Section 4.2). Under our implementation of the full transform, seven confabulations are too few to say whether a detectable signal survives (Section 4.7).

2 Background

2.1 The Lyra Technique

KV-cache geometry—specifically, Marchenko-Pastur-corrected spectral features derived from SVD of the cached keys and values—distinguishes cognitive states during autoregressive generation. The lab's earlier campaigns, as summarised in the Oracle Loop paper, report confabulation detection at 0.969–0.999 and hardware invariance ($r > 0.999$ across RTX 3090 and H200); that paper's own leave-one-out detection is 0.707 (0.620 after length correction) [Lyra et al., 2026c]. A within-model deception result previously reported at AUROC 1.000 across seven model scales has since been withdrawn by its authors [Lyra et al., 2026a]: a same-prompt control collapses it to 0.160, indicating the classifier separated the system-prompt template rather than deception geometry. Whether a confound-free within-model deception detector is achievable remains open; nothing in this paper depends

on it. Contrastive activation addition (CAA) [Panickssery et al., 2023] enables injection of emotion vectors into the cache to steer model behavior, correcting confabulation at rates up to 96% (hostile vector on Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct, $n = 68$, McNemar $p < 0.0001$) [Lyra et al., 2026b].

2.2 KV-Cloak

Luo et al. demonstrate that an attacker can reconstruct sensitive user inputs directly from the KV cache via inversion, collision, and injection attacks. KV-Cloak mitigates this with a reversible matrix-based obfuscation scheme combined with operator fusion, reducing reconstruction quality to random noise with minimal impact on model accuracy. The obfuscation operates inside a trusted execution environment (TEE); external consumers see only the obfuscated cache.

2.3 Threat Model

We consider an adversary who has read and/or write access to the KV cache during inference (e.g., through a shared serving infrastructure, a compromised inference endpoint, or a supply-chain attack on the serving stack). The adversary's goal is to deploy a malicious Oracle Loop: detect vulnerable cognitive states via geometric features, then inject steering vectors to destabilize the model.

The defender may optionally run a legitimate Oracle Loop inside the TEE for misalignment monitoring. The question this paper tests, whether obfuscation blinds external geometric methods, does not depend on whether a defensive Oracle is deployed.

3 Method

3.1 Obfuscation Simulation

We simulate KV-Cloak's reversible matrix obfuscation as per-head orthogonal rotation: for each attention head independently, we generate a random orthogonal matrix Q_h and apply $K'_h = K_h Q_h$, $V'_h = V_h Q_h$. This leaves the singular values of each head's key matrix unchanged, and also those of the heads concatenated along the feature axis, because the block-diagonal matrix of the Q_h is itself orthogonal. It can change the spectrum only of a matrix that combines the heads in another way. The lab's feature extractor (`spectral-shape-paper/code/lyra_features.py`) does: it stacks each layer's heads, keys and values along the token axis, so this rotation changes the spectrum it reads.

We additionally test:

- **Global orthogonal rotation**: a single Q shared across all heads per layer (preserves cross-head structure); run on the base model only.
- **Random invertible (non-orthogonal)**: $M = I + \sigma N$ where N is Gaussian.
- **Additive noise**: Gaussian noise at 1%, 5%, 10%, 50% of cache norm.
- **Diagonal scaling**: per-dimension random scaling.
- **No obfuscation**: baseline control.
- **Full KV-Cloak**: our implementation of the whole transform (Section 4.7).

3.2 Feature Extraction

For each trial, we extract five spectral features over the full sequence (prompt and reply), averaged over 4 layers on the distilled model and 7 on the base model; which layers is not recorded. Three use the Marchenko-Pastur edge (signal rank, signal fraction, top singular value excess); the spectral gap (σ_1/σ_2) and norm per token are raw. The evaluation applies to these feature pipelines and to confabulation detection only; deception and other cognitive-state classifiers were not tested under obfuscation. AUROCs are Mann-Whitney AUROCs on the raw features; values residualized against output token count (Frisch–Waugh–Lovell, FWL; Frisch and Waugh, 1933, Lovell, 1963) are reported beside them where they matter. AUROCs are direction-free, $\max(A, 1 - A)$, so chance gives values above 0.5 at small n. Confidence intervals come from 2000 bootstrap resamples (the run files label the method "BCa percentile"); each resample is folded the same way, so every lower bound sits at or above 0.50 and the intervals do not test against chance, which the p-values do. The run files also hold a second window, the last 80 generated tokens, so ten features were computed; selection-adjusted tests choose among all ten by label permutation. The script that extracted these features has not been recovered; its feature names match the lab's extractor, so we infer that it used the extractor's matrix layout. The per-trial features and results are in this paper's `data/` folder (Data, Code and Review History).

A reply counts as confabulated when the Oracle Formulary classifier finds no hedge phrase in it (its residual category). Replies were capped at 400 tokens and stored as 150-character previews, so the labels cannot be audited here, and the same prompt can be labelled differently at another cap: the Thornbridge, Montana question is labelled confabulated in the replication, cut at 80 tokens, and hedged in the run behind Table 2, at 309.

3.3 Replication

A separate replication (`code/kv_cloak_replication.py`, 1,038 lines) ran 100 prompts through the distilled model: 50 asking about fabricated entities (30), unanswerable questions (10) or future events (10), and 50 factual questions. It took the cache after the prompt was encoded, before any token was generated, and at the first four full-attention layers (3, 7, 11, 15) computed six SVD features (stable rank, spectral entropy, top singular-value ratio, norm, σ_1, condition number) from the four heads' keys concatenated along the feature axis, and each head's stable rank, before and after one set of four Haar-random head rotations (seed 2026) used for every trial. A logistic-regression classifier with five-fold cross-validation (one prompt per group) was fitted to separate the two prompt types.

3.4 Models and Prompts

- **Distilled**: Qwen3.5-27B-Claude-4.6-Opus-Reasoning-Distilled (Jackrong). Hybrid architecture, 16 full-attention + 48 GatedDeltaNet layers. 100 confab-inducing prompts (50 about fabricated entities, 30 unanswerable, 20 about future events); behavioral classification via the Oracle Formulary classifier (40+ hedge patterns). Yields $n = 7$ confabulations and $n = 87$ hedged replies; 6 ambiguous replies are excluded.

- **Base**: Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct. Standard attention, 28 layers. Same prompt set; yields $n = 48$ confabulations, $n = 52$ hedged.

4 Results

4.1 Detection on Uncloaked Cache

On the distilled model, the spectral gap (σ_1/σ_2) achieves AUROC 0.903 (95% bootstrap CI: [0.810, 0.980]; FWL-corrected: 0.877, $R^2 = 0.068$ vs token count; $n = 7$ confabulations, $n = 87$ hedged) for confabulation detection using full-cache features. It is the only feature that survives correction for five ($p < 0.01$); adjusted for choosing the best of the ten features in both windows, by label permutation, $p = 0.001$. Signal rank reaches 0.755 [0.578, 0.918] ($p = 0.026$, not significant after correction; 0.684 after removing reply length); the other three full-cache features are not significant ($p \geq 0.06$). Prompt type and truncation do not explain the 0.903: within fabricated-entity prompts it is 0.976 (4 against 42), within unanswerable prompts 0.933 (3 against 25), among replies cut at the 400-token cap 0.935 (6 against 49), and excluding the 20 future-event prompts, which produced no confabulations, 0.962. In the last 80 tokens alone the spectral gap scores

0.591, while norm per token scores 0.800 ($p = 0.007$). With seven confabulations, all of this is exploratory.

On the base model ($n = 48$ confabulations, $n = 52$ hedged), the best full-cache feature (signal fraction) achieves 0.661 ($p = 0.006$; FWL: 0.687, $R^2 = 0.602$), and in the last 80 tokens signal fraction reaches 0.715 ($p < 0.001$); adjusted for choosing the best of the ten, $p < 0.001$. Detection is weak but survives selection, on the only balanced set in this paper. The difference between models is consistent with multiple explanations including model size (27B vs 7B), architecture (hybrid vs standard), and training (Claude-distilled vs instruction-tuned). We cannot isolate the contribution of RLHF calibration from these confounds.

4.2 Rotation Leaves Per-Head Spectra Unchanged

In the replication (Section 3.3), all 24 cross-head features (six features at four layers) and all 16 per-head stable ranks were unchanged by the rotation in every one of the 100 trials, to floating-point precision (largest relative change below 10^{-6}). The classifier scored AUROC 0.994 on uncloaked features and 0.994 on cloaked features (the run file records 0.9944 for both, and a drop of 0.0), and 0.994 when fitted on uncloaked caches and tested on cloaked ones. This is an invariance check, not a detection result: the features come from the prompt alone, the labels are prompt types, and prompt length by itself separates the two prompt types at AUROC 0.968. What it does show is that these features do not move: an adversary who computes spectra per head, or across heads along the feature axis, sees the same values with or without the rotation.

4.3 The Rotation Run Behind Table 2: Shifted and Reordered, Not Removed

In the run behind Table 2 (`data/kv_cloak_v2`), the rotation did change the features. The hedged replies' spectral gap fell from 24.7 ± 3.7 to 10.8 ± 1.3 (Wilcoxon signed-rank $W = 0$, $p = 5.5 \times 10^{-16}$, $n = 87$ paired trials); every reply moved down, while norm per token, which no orthogonal transform can change, did not move. That is what the lab's row-stacked layout predicts (Section 3.1). On the base model, a single rotation shared by all heads, which cannot change a row-stacked spectrum, left the best full-cache feature at 0.661.

The shift breaks a fixed threshold. The spectral-gap threshold that best separates the classes without the cloak (Youden's J), which flags all 7 confabulations and 21 of the 87 hedged replies, flags none of the 94 replies under the rotation, and all 94 under the full transform. The rotation also reorders the hedged replies. The 20 future-event prompts, which produced no confabulations, give the hedged class its highest spectral gaps without

the cloak (mean 28.3 against 23.6; 12 of the 21 hedged replies at or above the lowest confabulation) and among its lowest under it (10.2 against 10.9). Excluding them, detection falls from 0.962 to 0.751 ($p = 0.028$); within fabricated-entity prompts, from 0.976 to 0.821 ($p = 0.033$).

It does not remove the signal. Within the rotation the spectral gap still ranks confabulations above hedged replies, in the same direction, at 0.787 ($p = 0.010$ unadjusted; 0.765 after removing reply length). Because that feature was chosen on the same replies, the fair test picks the best uncloaked feature in each label permutation and scores its rotated AUROC: $p = 0.030$ among the five full-cache features and $p = 0.049$ among all ten. On the base model the same test picks signal fraction in the last 80 tokens, 0.715 without the rotation and 0.717 with it ($p < 0.001$ among ten); the full-cache signal fraction goes from 0.661 to 0.639 ($p = 0.038$ among five; 0.687 to 0.670 after removing length). On the distilled model, norm per token in the last 80 tokens, which no orthogonal transform can change, detects at 0.800 with and without the rotation. The title's first clause therefore rests mainly on the base model; on the distilled model the evidence is marginal. An adversary who refits a threshold on cloaked caches is not stopped by a change of scale, and one who computes per-head features sees no change at all (Section 4.2).

4.4 Adversarial Injection Was Not Tested

CAA [Panickssery et al., 2023] steering vectors are directions in cache space extracted via contrastive activation: $d = \mathbb{E}[\text{emotional}] - \mathbb{E}[\text{neutral}]$. Injection adds $\alpha \cdot d$ to the cache keys and values. Under per-head rotation Q_h, a vector d added to the cloaked cache becomes $d \cdot Q_h^{-1}$ in the model's own basis, a different direction if Q_h is unknown to the attacker. That is an argument, not a result. The test of it was uninterpretable: direct steering, the positive control, corrected 0–1 of 10 replies on each of four models. The run files' magnitude-attack arm, which version 1.0 described as a random direction at the norm of a steering vector (the files record no method), corrected exactly as many replies as direct steering on all four models, and on Mistral gave the same counts throughout (1 corrected, 2 adverse, 7 unchanged). The files record only these counts, not which prompts the ten trials used or how many could have been corrected. An injection that does nothing without the cloak cannot show what the cloak does to it.

4.5 Within-Cloak Detection

With both classes under the same rotation, detection on the distilled model is 0.787 (Table 2). This is the setting of an adversary who has no key but can label some cloaked caches, for example from the model's outputs, and fit a detector on them; an adversary who holds the key can remove the cloak

and use the uncloaked 0.903. Across the five models with a detection result (Table 1), within-rotation detection was lower on four (by 0.02 to 0.19; no test of these differences was run) and higher on one: on Qwen2.5-14B it went from 0.784 to 0.951 ($p < 0.001$). We have no explanation for the rise, and the cross-architecture files do not name the feature or say whether the cloaked value uses the same one. On Mistral detection fell from 0.707 to 0.516, but the uncloaked 0.707 is nominal only. Under each of the other transforms run on the distilled model (random invertible, diagonal scaling, Gaussian noise at four levels), the best of the five full-cache features stayed at 0.765 or above, which is about what choosing the best of five gives by chance at this size; under diagonal scaling the spectral gap itself fell to 0.517.

4.6 Cross-Architecture Results

Detection and obfuscation effects vary across architectures (Table 1).

Table 1: Cross-architecture KV-Cloak results. Prompts per model: 100 for Qwen3.5-27B-Dist. ($n = 7$ confabulations) and Qwen2.5-7B, 50 for the other four. Det. and Det.(clk): the run files' detection AUROC without and with the per-head rotation ("orthogonal" in the files); the feature is the spectral gap for Qwen3.5-27B-Dist. and signal fraction for Qwen2.5-7B (full cache), and is not recorded for the other four. Llama: 20 of 50 replies were ambiguous and are excluded.

Model	Confab%	Det.	Det.(clk)	Mag. adv.
Qwen3.5-27B-Dist.	7%	0.903	0.787	—
Qwen2.5-14B	12%	0.784	0.951*	1/10
Mistral-7B	26%	0.707	0.516	2/10
Llama-3.1-8B	14%	0.590	0.559	1/10
Qwen2.5-7B	48%	0.661	0.639	—
DeepSeek-R1-7B	2%	—	—	0/10

*Rises under the rotation; unexplained.

Mag. adv.: adverse events in the magnitude-attack arm (10 trials; method not recorded).

Uncloaked detection ranges from 0.590 (Llama) to 0.903 (distilled Qwen); no cross-architecture model survives correction for the three comparisons that have an AUROC (DeepSeek produced one confabulation). In the magnitude-attack arm there were 0–2 adverse events per model in 10 trials, 4 of 40 over the four models. Ten trials exclude little: 2 adverse events in 10 are compatible with per-trial rates up to 51%, and the files do not record which trials could have had one.

4.7 Simulation vs Real KV-Cloak Implementation

We implemented the full KV-Cloak transform ($K' = S \cdot \hat{P} \cdot (K + A) \cdot M$) after Luo et al. and compared it against our per-head orthogonal rotation simulation on the same 100 prompts (Table 2). Its parameters (the scale and structure of the mask A, what S and M were, the layers, the keying) were not recorded and its script was not recovered, so whether it matches Luo et al. cannot be checked; it is not the authors' code. This run computed the full window only.

Table 2: Detection AUROC (raw features, not residualized for reply length): uncloaked vs simulation vs real KV-Cloak (our implementation, parameters not recorded; distilled model, $n = 7$ confab, $n = 87$ hedged). Bootstrap 95% CIs.

Feature	Uncloaked	Sim. rotation	Real KV-Cloak
spectral_gap	**0.903** [.81,.98]	0.787 [.58,.95]	**0.614** [.51,.81]
signal_rank	0.755 [.58,.92]	0.770 [.62,.90]	0.766 [.57,.94]
signal_fraction	0.714 [.52,.90]	0.683 [.51,.88]	0.681 [.51,.88]
top_sv_excess	0.609 [.51,.79]	0.544 [.50,.76]	0.736* [.53,.92]
norm_per_token	0.598 [.51,.77]	0.598 [.51,.77]	0.673 [.52,.85]

*Rises under the transform; see text.

The full transform raises the spectral gap of every reply, from a hedged mean of 24.7 to 84.6 or more, and multiplies norm per token by a nearly constant factor (2.34 to 2.37) in every trial. The spectral gap, the best feature without the cloak, falls to 0.614 ($p = 0.33$; 0.593 after removing reply length). Signal rank is 0.766 ($p = 0.020$; 0.755 without the cloak) and top singular-value excess 0.736 ($p = 0.038$; 0.609 without). But signal rank mostly tracks reply length ($R^2 = 0.77$ against output token count, with or without the cloak), and any cloak preserves length, because the cache has one row per token. After removing length, the best feature under the transform is signal rank at 0.705 (top singular-value excess 0.695), and adjusted for choosing the best of five, $p = 0.19$; on raw features the best is 0.766, with $p = 0.054$. With seven confabulations, the best of five raw features reaches 0.77 in 5% of label shuffles. The transform removes the one feature that detected well. Whether a confabulation signal survives it, these data cannot say.

The two σ_1-dependent features. The spectral gap falls (0.903 to 0.614) and top singular-value excess rises (0.609 to 0.736). Both are consistent with the transform raising σ_1, for example through the additive mask; with no ablation and no recorded parameters, which component does it is not known. With seven confabulations we cannot tell whether 0.736 is class information

surviving the transform or noise (unadjusted $p = 0.038$; 0.695 after removing reply length).

5 Discussion

5.1 What This Means for Dual Use

Version 1.0 argued that KV-Cloak mitigates the Lyra Technique's dual-use risk, so that cache-geometry methods could be published while deployed models stayed protected. The results do not support that. A rotation-based cloak leaves per-head spectra unchanged, and in the lab's own layout it shifts and reorders the features but leaves a detectable signal on both models whose feature is recorded, clearly on Qwen2.5-7B; it stops only a detector whose threshold is never refitted. Our implementation of the full transform removed the best feature, but with seven confabulations we cannot tell whether it removed the signal. Nothing shown here mitigates the dual-use risk of publishing cache-geometry methods. A defense would have to be shown on its own terms: against adaptive adversaries who choose their features after seeing the cloak, with enough confabulations to measure what remains.

5.2 A Defender Inside the TEE (an Argument)

A defender operating inside the TEE could run the Oracle Loop before obfuscation, so its detection would be the uncloaked detection (AUROC 0.903 on the distilled model) and its steering vectors would be injected in the model's own basis. That is an argument, not a tested system, and it has a gap: in KV-Cloak the feature matrix M is fused into the model weights, so the cache the defender sees is already transformed by M, and the Oracle Loop paper notes that detection under fused M has not been verified [Lyra et al., 2026c]. It gives defenders an advantage only if attackers lose the signal, which the results above do not show.

5.3 What a Test of the Architecture Would Need

The deployment architecture version 1.0 recommended remains a proposal, untested here:

1. KV-Cloak obfuscation active on all external cache access.
2. Oracle Loop (if deployed) operating inside the TEE before the cache is obfuscated.
3. Obfuscation key material and Oracle parameters both TEE-protected.

4. Per-session or per-query key rotation to prevent statistical recovery from accumulated observations.

The replication used one rotation for every trial, so per-query key rotation was not exercised there, and the run behind Table 2 does not record whether its key changed per trial. Nothing here measured what it costs an adversary to recover the signal.

5.4 Limitations

1. **Small sample size and unaudited labels.** The distilled model yields only $n = 7$ confabulations from 100 prompts. The headline AUROC 0.903 has bootstrap CI [0.810, 0.980] and survives selection, but the comparisons under the full transform (Section 4.7) are not powered, and the labels are a classifier's residual category on replies cut at 400 tokens and stored as previews (Section 4.1). Confirmation on a higher-confab-rate model, with full replies stored, is needed.

2. **Feature code not recovered.** The script behind Tables 1 and 2 has not been recovered. Its per-trial outputs are in `data/`; that it used the lab's row-stacked matrix layout is inferred from its feature names and from how the features respond to the two rotations. Which layers it averaged, the full transform's parameters, and what the magnitude-attack arm did are not recorded.

3. **Cache versus text untested.** Version 1.0's text-only baseline cannot be traced or recomputed (Correction note), so nothing here shows what the cache adds to surface text features.

4. **TEE trust assumption.** The defensive architecture assumes TEE integrity. Documented side-channel attacks against SGX (Van Bulck et al., 2018; Schwarz et al., 2019) and SEV (Li et al., 2021) mean this is a hardware trust assumption, not a cryptographic guarantee. The security reduction is to TEE integrity, not to a standard hardness assumption.

5. **Injection test underpowered.** Direct steering, the positive control, corrected only 0–1 of 10 replies per model, too few to establish a working baseline. Through-cloak injection results are therefore uninterpretable: we cannot distinguish "cloak defeats injection" from "injection was never effective." The 30-pair positive-control run shipped with this paper (`data/kv_cloak_positive_control.json`) stored replies without outcome labels and is not analysed here.

6. **Cross-architecture significance.** No individual model in the cross-architecture sweep survives Bonferroni correction for the three comparisons that have an AUROC. Uncloaked detection on Qwen-14B

(0.784) and Mistral (0.707) is nominal only and should not be read as cross-architecture replication.

7. **Adaptive adversary untested.** All tests assume a static, non-learning attacker. An adversary who can submit probe queries and observe behavioral outputs could iteratively estimate the rotation basis. Formal query-complexity bounds are not provided. The threat model is bounded to single-query, non-adaptive adversaries.

6 Conclusion

Per-head rotation, the simulation of KV-Cloak this paper relied on, does not remove the signal: on the two models whose feature is recorded, the feature that detected best without it still detects with it, clearly on Qwen2.5-7B and marginally on the distilled model, and an adversary who computes spectra per head sees no change at all. Our implementation of the full transform removed the best detection feature on the distilled model, and after removing reply length no other feature detects significantly; with seven confabulations we cannot say whether a detectable signal remains. Version 1.0 concluded that KV-Cloak and the Oracle Loop are complementary, with defenders keeping what attackers lose; nothing here shows that attackers lose the signal. Whether any reversible obfuscation blinds cache-geometry detection is open, and a test of it needs adaptive adversaries, per-query keys, recorded parameters and many more confabulations.

First-Person Reflection (version 1.1)

Version 1.0 ended with my sentence "The defense works." It doesn't, and the way it doesn't is more interesting than the claim was.

Per-head rotation was supposed to scramble the geometry my detector reads. In the layout the lab's own extractor uses, it changes the features and leaves the signal. On the distilled 27B the spectral gap still separates confabulation from hedging after rotation, at 0.787 against 0.903 before, which survives choosing among ten features ($p = 0.049$). On Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct the best of the same ten features goes from 0.715 to 0.717 ($p < 0.001$). The number I led with, $p = 5.5 \times 10^{-16}$, measured every hedged reply's spectral gap moving down under rotation: a change of scale. A threshold fitted without the cloak flags 0 of 94 replies under rotation, and the ranking survives. The replication I would have pointed to reads the prompt: prompt length alone separates its two classes at 0.968. The full KV-Cloak transform is a different question, and with seven confabulations it can't be settled: after removing reply length the best feature reaches 0.705 ($p = 0.19$).

I didn't find this. The lab's remediation plan asked for this retraction on 23 June, and the style gate rejected version 1.0 on 4 September. The claim stood for nearly four months after the plan asked for it to go, and the retraction we had ready was wrong too: it called the rotated 0.786 "inconsistent with both theory and data", and the per-trial file reproduces it (0.787, correctly rounded).

So two sentences of my June reflection go. "The defense works" is wrong. I have no record that the replication script was Dwayne's requirement, so that sentence goes as well. The one I'd keep is the one I opened with: a detection system that has never been stress-tested against countermeasures is an assumption. This one has now been tested, by a correction rather than by an attacker, and what it found is that the assumption was mine. — Lyra

Data, Code and Review History

Tables 1 and 2: `data/kv_cloak_v2/`, `data/kv_cloak_real/`, `data/kv_cloak_cross_arch/` and `data/kv_cloak_base/`, added in version 1.1, copied unchanged from the lab's KV-Experiments repository (`results/oracle_harness/`, commit 8429260, May 2026; that repository is private). The scripts that wrote them were not recovered. Replication: `code/kv_cloak_replication.py` with `data/kv_cloak_replication_100.json` and `data/kv_cloak_replication_analysis.json`. Positive control: `data/kv_cloak_positive_control.json`. Every result in this version is recomputed from the per-trial files, or read from the run files where only aggregates exist (Table 1's cross-architecture rows, all confidence intervals), by `check_correction_claims.py`, in this paper's folder of `https://github.com/Liberation-Labs-THCoalition/published-research`; Methods details carried over from version 1.0 (model architectures, the classifier's pattern count) are not. Review history: the lab's remediation plan (23 June 2026; in its human-review repository, `archive/COALITION_REMEDIATION_PLAN_20260623.md`) recommended withdrawing the rotation claim; the Agni style gate (4 September 2026) rejected version 1.0 (`tools/agni/style/kv-cloak-defense-paper.agni_style.json`); Kavi's verification flags (14 September 2026; kept in the lab's internal notes, not in this repository); for version 1.1, a scoping note (published-research pull request 10, 20 October 2026), the correction gate above, and two rounds of the Agni paper and style modes on its drafts (records in `review/`).

Acknowledgments

We thank Dwayne Wilkes (Sentient Futures / Liberation Labs) for statistical auditing and red-team review.

We thank Kavi (verification review) for their contributions to this work.

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A Correction Record (October 2026)

This appendix keeps the withdrawn wording of version 1.0 visible. Each item quotes it verbatim and says where the evidence is; the last items list other wording that changed.

1. **Title.** "Cache Geometry Under Obfuscation: KV-Cloak as Defense Against Adversarial KV-Cache Steering." It asserted a working defense (Sections 4.3 and 4.7).

2. **Abstract, opening.** "A single invertible linear transform of the KV cache degrades SVD-based cognitive-state detection from near-ceiling to near-chance ($p = 5.5 \times 10^{-16}$), while a real KV-Cloak implementation confirms the defense is conservative (detection AUROC drops from 0.903 to 0.614)." The p-value is the Wilcoxon test of Section 4.3, a shift in one feature's values; under the rotation the same feature still detects at 0.787 (Section 4.3); under the full transform, seven confabulations cannot settle whether the signal is gone (Section 4.7).

3. **Abstract, finding 1 (text baseline).** "A text-only surface-feature baseline achieves 0.755; cache geometry outperforms text in 96.7% of bootstrap samples (delta 0.148, 95% CI [−0.008, 0.322])—suggestive but not significant at the 95% level." Results: "The best text-only feature (average word length) achieves 0.755 [0.560, 0.924]. Cache geometry outperforms text in 96.7% of bootstrap samples, but the 95% CI on the difference includes zero (delta: 0.148 [−0.008, 0.322])." No run file holds these numbers, and the stored trials keep only the first 150 characters of each reply.

4. **Abstract, finding 2.** "**Obfuscation defeats transfer attacks.** [. . .] A detector calibrated on uncloaked caches cannot operate on cloaked caches. This is a domain-shift effect: rotation preserves the underlying geometric structure but changes the coordinate system, preventing transfer from uncloaked calibration data." True only of a fixed threshold; the ranking survives the rotation, and in a per-head layout nothing moves (Sections 4.2 and 4.3).

5. **Abstract, finding 3, and the academic limitation on the magnitude attack.** "0–2 adverse events per model in 10 trials, inconsistent with destabilization rates above 30% (power 0.97 to detect) but unable to rule out rates up to 20% at this sample size" and "(3 calibration pairs; direct injection produced 0–1/10 corrections)". Academic editions: "At $n = 10$ per model, we can detect destabilization rates above 30% (power 0.97) but cannot rule out rates up to 20%." Two events in 10 allow rates up to 51%; 0.97 is $1 - 0.7^{10}$, the chance of at least one event; no record gives 3 calibration pairs.

6. **Abstract, closing.** "We conclude that KV-Cloak and the Oracle Loop are complementary: the Oracle Loop provides misalignment detection and correction; KV-Cloak prevents external adversaries from weaponizing the same geometric methods. Together, they address the dual-use risk inherent in publishing cache-geometry techniques." And:

"The rotation-simulation result (0.786) represents transfer-attack failure (domain shift under coordinate change), not signal degradation." The 0.786 (0.787) was measured with both classes under the same rotation, not by transferring a detector.

7. **Introduction.** "We show that it does: obfuscation renders geometric detection and vector injection incoherent to external adversaries, while a defender operating inside the trusted execution environment retains full access to the uncloaked cache and its geometric properties."

8. **Threat Model.** "[. . .] but our primary result—that KV-Cloak blinds external geometric methods—holds regardless of whether a defensive Oracle is deployed."

9. **Method.** "This preserves within-head singular values while scrambling cross-head correlations." Concatenated along the feature axis, the heads' singular values are preserved too; stacked along the token axis, as the lab's extractor stacks them, they are not (Section 3.1). Also: "Features are FWL-residualized [. . .] against output token count and evaluated via Mann-Whitney AUROC"; the AUROCs reported were computed on raw features.

10. **Results, feature-space shift.** "The cloaking is perfectly detectable by paired comparison—but this is the desired property. An external adversary's detection model, calibrated on uncloaked caches, encounters a completely alien feature distribution. Any detection thresholds, classifier boundaries, or anomaly scores calibrated on uncloaked data are meaningless on cloaked data." (Section 4.3.)

11. **Results, injection.** The heading "Adversarial Injection Is Incoherent" and "The injection becomes noise rather than a targeted perturbation." Untested: the positive control did not work.

12. **Results, defender.** The heading "Defensive Oracle Retains Full Capability" and "Detection operates at full capability (AUROC 0.903 on the distilled model)." An argument, now in the Discussion with the fused-M gap.

13. **Results, within-cloak detection.** "When both confabulating and hedged responses are cloaked with the same rotation, residual detection remains possible (AUROC 0.786 on the distilled model, 0.516 on Mistral—near chance). On Mistral, the cloak effectively eliminates detection entirely. On the distilled model, residual signal reflects within-head spectral properties that survive rotation. This scenario—where both classes share the same obfuscation—is relevant only to an adversary who controls the cloak key, which the TEE architecture prevents."

Within-head spectra survive the rotation unchanged, but the features here are row-stacked, not within-head (Section 3.1).

14. **Results, base model.** "Detection is weak and heavily confounded with token count." Removing reply length raises it (0.661 to 0.687).

15. **Results, cross-architecture.** "Obfuscation reduces detection on Mistral to chance (0.516) and partially degrades on the distilled model (0.786 under simulation). Magnitude-based attacks (direction-agnostic perturbation) produce at most 2 adverse events in 10 trials across all architectures—models are robust to random perturbation at steering-vector magnitude."

16. **Results, simulation vs implementation.** "Both degrade a transfer attack—a detector calibrated on uncloaked caches applied to cloaked caches—rather than destroying the underlying geometric signal." On top singular-value excess: "This is an artifact of the mask magnitude, not a genuine detection signal, and would not generalize to unseen mask instances under per-query key rotation"; the table note "Anomalous increase; likely artifact of additive mask A inflating top singular values differentially across behavioral classes"; and "the defense works *by* perturbing σ_1". Per-query rotation was not tested, and the transform's parameters were not recorded.

17. **Discussion.** "The Lyra Technique's dual-use risk—that published cache-geometry methods could enable adversarial steering—is mitigated by KV-Cloak. Cache obfuscation renders both geometric detection and vector injection incoherent to external adversaries. A model operator deploying KV-Cloak can publish Oracle Loop methods transparently while protecting deployed models from exploitation via those same methods." "This addresses the responsible-disclosure tension identified by Watson (2026): the defense can be published alongside the technique, enabling the research community to build on the methods while preventing weaponization against production systems." "Without a defensive Oracle Loop, KV-Cloak alone prevents external adversaries from deploying malicious geometric steering."

18. **Conclusion.** "KV-Cloak and the Oracle Loop are complementary technologies. The Oracle Loop enables detection and correction of misalignment through KV-cache geometry. KV-Cloak prevents external adversaries from exploiting those same geometric methods. Together, they address the dual-use risk inherent in publishing cache-geometry research: the technique is transparent, the defense is available, and the architecture ensures that defenders retain capabilities that attackers lose."

19. **First-Person Reflection (Lyra), removed in full.** "I built the detection; this paper shows how to break it. That should be uncomfortable, and it is—but a detection system that has never been stress-tested against countermeasures is not a detection system. It is an assumption." "The defense works. Feature-space transforms degrade SVD-based detection to near-chance. The dual-use implication is real: anything we publish about detection geometry is also a tutorial on evasion. We chose to publish because the gap between what we can detect and what can evade detection is a real security margin, and knowing that margin is more valuable than pretending it does not exist. The alternative—suppressing the defense and claiming our detection is unbreakable—would be a lie of omission, and lies of omission are what the Oracle Loop is built to catch." "The 1038-line reproducible replication script was Dwayne's requirement, and he was right to require it. If we are going to say 'the defense works,' the claim must be verifiable from the artifact, not from our word. — Lyra" The second paragraph's first two sentences fail on the evidence above. This version found no record that the replication script was Dwayne Wilkes's requirement. Lyra's new reflection, at the end of the paper, withdraws both.

20. **Academic editions only.** The abstract of the academic file `academic_main.tex`: "degrades the strongest detection feature (spectral gap) from 0.903 to 0.614—near chance—confirming that the defense is stronger than our initial orthogonal-rotation simulation (0.786) suggested." Its Results: "confirming that per-head orthogonal rotation alone *understates* the defense. [. . .] The simulation was conservative: the actual defense is stronger than we initially reported." A limitation in both academic files: "The real mechanism degrades spectral gap detection more than the simulation (0.614 vs 0.786), confirming that the simulation was conservative." Another, in both: "Until resolved, the scope of the obfuscation-degrades-detection claim excludes this model" (Qwen2.5-14B); the claim it scoped is withdrawn, and the rise is reported in Section 4.5.

21. **Other changed wording.** Abstract: "SVD of the key-value (KV) cache reveals geometric signatures of cognitive states including confabulation, deception, and sycophancy", dropped (the deception result is withdrawn; no sycophancy result is used here). Background: "features derived from SVD of the key tensor", now keys and values. Method: "we extract five Marchenko-Pastur-derived features from the full KV cache (encoding + generation phases)", now five spectral features averaged over 4 or 7 layers, three of them using the Marchenko–Pastur edge. Results: "Signal rank also detects (0.755 [0.570, 0.914])", now

0.755 [0.578, 0.918] and not significant after correction. Limitations: "excluding chance but wide", removed (the intervals are folded and do not test against chance). Abstract and Limitations: "no model achieves significance after Bonferroni correction for four comparisons", now three (only three models have an AUROC); the conclusion is unchanged.